The Great Nicobar and Agalega Islands: Fortifying Indian Ocean with strategical infrastructures

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Abstract:

While the Atlantic Ocean was the pivot in 20th-century world politics, the currents have drifted towards the Indo-Pacific in recent decades. The Indian Ocean is especially the heart of contemporary strategies for global dominance. Given its flourishing trade for civilizations, rich biodiversity, and geo-political importance the Indian Ocean is on the radars of all strategies. Following the crucial position of the Indian Ocean both traditional and non-traditional security issues come as strings attached. While any developments in the Indian Ocean are directly concerned with India`s national security our stakes and responsibility in the region are the most compared to any player. Indian Navy constantly ensures the entire region is free and open for navigation and ensures its dominance with its admiring operational capacity. Strategic locations are crucial in governing such a big region. Here is where the Great Nicobar Island in the East and the Agalega Islands of Mauritius in the West become important. With the proposed Great Nicobar project to convert the island into a transshipment hub and build a self-sustainable green field airport, India ensures its strategic domination of the Malacca Strait. Similarly, in the West India-funded establishment of crucial infrastructures in Agalega Island will bolster Indian Ocean security architecture. This paper will try to probe how these two projects will help in the fortification of the Indian Ocean which is second to none in India`s national security strategy which ensures no dragon can breach Varuna`s Makara.

Key Words:

Indian Ocean, National security, Great Nicobar island, Agalega island.

Introduction:

Alfred Mahan Says the control of a nation towards oceans determines its economic and political power. History also adds value to his statement. As scholars argue the 21st century is the Indian century, and India`s quest for its sea power plays an impeccable role in its growth and security. Especially, the Indian Ocean has gained prominence for geo-strategic value as history is repeating itself, one point in history where 90% of global trade happened in the Indian Ocean alone. India historically had dominance over the region and in recent context, Indian Ocean security is the most important factor of India`s national security.

With China playing an assertive role in the maritime domain and strengthening its capabilities for its far-reaching ambitions on the Indian Ocean, it is important for India to strategically

fortify the Indian Ocean with critical infrastructure and maintain an edge above any other nation in the Indian Ocean.

This competitive edge can be achieved by investing in strategic infrastructural developments. During the 11th century when the Eastern Indian Ocean was boiling with piracy and hefty levies, the mighty Cholas ensured the freedom of navigation far before the concept of freedom of navigation had even been introduced. In that case, the Strait of Malacca is a crucial choke point, that can give dominance to India vis-à-vis securitizing the Eastern part of the Indian Ocean.

The Great Nicobar Islands which is in the vicinity of the Strait of Malacca is a strategic treasure. In 2021 NITI Ayog India`s premier policy advisory body, came up with a plan for infrastructural developments on the island. This project has the potential to re-write the dynamics of the Indian Ocean trade and security architecture.

Similarly, in the Western part of the Indian Ocean, which is infested with piracy and heightened terror activities, it is crucial to keep the waters safe and confident for the merchant ships to sail. An extensive network of Archipelagos can help in this regard. Mauritius an Archipelago island nation that shares a civilizational bond with India and Indian migrants played an important role in developing the nation. India-Mauritius relations especially focused on security and strategy will be a win-win situation for both these nations and can help in effective law and order management of the Indian Ocean and Ocean governance to a larger extent.

By building important infrastructures like Naval bases, and airstrips, establishing human settlements, developing new projects, enhancing trade and tourism, improved connectivity under India`s stewardship, India can ensure its responsible and trustworthy role in upholding the sovereignty of the region.

Our national security does not end with the mainland but goes far and deep into the Ocean. It is more challenging and complex in the oceans, which are predominantly ungoverned for better surveillance and make it a crime-free zone. While India has adversaries in both East and West of its littoral boundaries, India cannot afford to have adversaries in its waters also. Securitizing the Indian Ocean should be a second nonpriority.

In order to protect such a vast landscape, well-distributed, connected, infrastructure is important. Only then it is possible for effective governance of the Indian Ocean. The Great Nicobar Project and Indo-Mauritius relations are two rewarding concepts, that will ensure Indian control over the vast ocean and bolster, and secure the Indian Ocean which is an undeniable part of India`s national security.

The Great Nicobar Project:

Veteran Indian Historian K M Panikkar has rightly pointed out the strategic importance of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands have strategic potential to push India`s strategic calculations beyond South Asia. It acts as a lynchpin between South Asia and South East Asian nations. The islands have also got India more Exclusive Economic Zone EEZ in the Bay of Bengal.

In the early 20th century when Stamford Raffles set up a military outpost in Singapore, considering the advantage with Malacca. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands also got similar advantages. The Island groups are rich in flora and fauna and contribute a great value to Indian tourism and also in terms of security when utilized properly. The British undermined the value of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and used it as a safe haven to deport the freedom movement leaders. After independence sadly it took a lot of time to come out of the situation and a more strategic push is required to develop the region.

Andaman and Nicobar Islands got a new impetus in India`s national security domain when the first theatre command of India, the Andaman and Nicobar Command was established in the year 2001. After the establishment of the theatre command, the tri-services forces access to the Indian Ocean increased multitude and it went beyond Indian Ocean territory. It paved the way for better monitoring and surveillance in the Bay of Bengal region. The swift action of the Andaman and Nicobar command after the devastating tsunami of 2004 and its immaculate effort to bring back the area to normalcy shows how important the region is not only for India but extended South East Asia.

The strategic advantages of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands are finally realized and importance has begun to be given especially in terms of national security. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands stand as a center point of the South Asia and South East Asia narrative or even in the greater concept of the Indo Pacific which begins from the Eastern Coast of Africa and goes to the Western coast of the Americas where the Andaman and Nicobar islands act as a pivot in all such narratives.

New Enthusiasm for Andaman and Nicobar Islands was born when the NITI Ayog India`s premier policy advisory body came up with an ambitious goal of a 72,000 crore mega investment project in the Southernmost tip of the island groups the Great Nicobar Island. The Government of India is also planning an ambitious road development project from Zero Point to the Southernmost tip of India the Indira Point which is a 56-kilo meter road project which will make Indira Point accessible for all tourists.

The Great Nicobar Project is a 72,000-crore ambitious infrastructure development project. This project aims to build a transshipment hub, a greenfield airport, and a combined gas, and solar power plant with 450 MVA capacity which will make the island self-sufficient. The aimed project will bring down the role of the Chinese-built and operated Hambantota port in Sri Lanka. By building a transshipment hub in the region India can effectively regulate the cargo transport of the Indian Ocean.

The strait of Malacca alone holds about 3.5 trillion US dollars worth of goods annually. This also includes two-thirds of entire Chinese goods operated on the same route. By establishing a transshipment hub in close proximity to such a crucial trade route India can reap a lot of economic benefits out of it. The strategic point of view is that when foreign countries' goods especially Chinese goods become dependent on the Indian transshipment hub it keeps us in a safer position where India gets a strategic advantage because it will self-harm a nation on any attempt to challenge India. By building a greenfield airport, Indian dominance can also be established in the skies. The Airport can be used for refuelling, maintenance, and repair for the fighter jets and can respond to distress situations effectively. Also with the help of the airport more tourist attractions can be brought in especially when more foreign tourists are attracted it will add prominence to the region.

The project will also help in strengthening the people-to-people connection between the Indian population and South East Asia, especially Indonesia and Malaysia, for people who are moving for employment. The project is still in the nascent stage due to its environmental constraints. However, when planned and executed accordingly the project can be established successfully without harming the ecological value of the island. The Great Nicobar Project will add new impetus to the development of the Andaman and Nicobar region without harming its pristine ecology.

The real strategic advantage of the project is harnessed with its military capabilities. The transshipment hub when developed with prior advancements can also be used as a dual-use military facility with which the Indian Navy can get complete dominance of the Strait of Malacca region. It can also ensure the freedom of navigation across the strait cannot be compromised by any external player

During a distress situation or whenever India`s external security is challenged this critical asset has immense potential to stall the entire global supply chain system in no time. Also, Indian priorities during any supply chain crisis can also be maintained. This transshipment hub ensures India`s national security cannot be compromised both in security as well as economic terms. India-ASEAN relations will get a new josh with this project. With existing projects like the Kaldan Multi-model project and trilateral highway and other projects India-ASEAN trade can be improved to new heights.

The Great Nicobar project has its best potential to harness sea power to improve India`s National Security.

Agalega Island Air Strip

Mauritius is an East African island archipelago situated 1100 nautical miles from the Eastern coast of Africa. The island was a colony of the British since the 18th century and gained independence in 1968. The island's economy is predominantly dependent on tourism and agriculture where sugar, clothing, and salt are its primary exports. Mauritius has an Exclusive Economic Zone of 2.3 million square kilometre which also controls nearby islands including Saint Brandon, Agalega, and Tronden under its control. Mauritius is located in a strategically important area where it is accessible to the extensive coast of East Africa, also West Asia.

India`s relations with Mauritius are deeply rooted where about 70% of Mauritius's population are immigrants from India. Nearly 47% of the Mauritius population follows Hinduism as their religion. Most of the people who settled there take back their ancestry to the states of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Between the 1800s to 1920, the British government took around half a million population from India to Mauritius to work in the sugarcane plantations. The migrants also carried their culture and traditions along with them which has linked India-Mauritius relations deeply which is benefitting both the nations in contemporary times.

Given the resource crunch of Mauritius, the nation is highly dependent on financial aid and foreign investments for its growth and development. India has been a reliable partner for decades in Mauritius's growth and development. India is the largest trading partner of Mauritius which exceeds 500 million US dollars every year. India has invested 20 billion US dollars as foreign investment. India alone exports around 450 million US dollars worth of goods every year. Over the last 10 years, Mauritius has received nearly 1000 million US dollars as a Line of Credit from India and 400 million US dollars as financial assistance.

Union Budget 2024 of India has increased the grants to Mauritius which shows the growing relevance of the relations between the two nations.

Agalega Island is a tiny group of 2 islands that is under the control of Mauritius. The island is located 650 nautical miles north of the Mauritius. The size of the island is 26 square kilometers and only 300 people live in the island. It takes two days to connect between Agalega Island and mainland Mauritius. Most of the island is inhabited but the island has got strategic potential due to its geography. The Agalega island is located in close proximity to the Mozambique Channel and the Re-Union islands which are under French control. India already has good relations with the French Re Union islands where this island group possesses a strategic advantage.

On 29 February 2024, Indian Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi along with the Mauritius Prime Minister jointly inaugurated the newly built airstrip and a jetty in the Agalega island. The project was funded and built by India to help connect Agalega. During the inauguration, the Prime Minister of India called the Mauritius a natural partner. The Mauritius Prime Minister also affirmed India`s partnership with SAGAR vision. The airstrip is seen as a strategic move by India to ensure its presence in the region.

The Chinese have established their 1st overseas naval base Djibouti. Their assertion on East African countries and Maldives is also growing. India recently faced a setback in the Maldives where the Indian forces stationed in Maldives for operation and maintenance of the Dornier aircraft which India gifted the Maldives were asked to leave the country.

Swiftly, India took a strategic choice of engaging its cultural, natural partner Mauritius to uphold Indian dominance in the Indian Ocean region. The Agelaga island will ensure India`s geo-strategic dominance over the region which is crucial for India`s national security.

During French Prime Minister Immanuel Macron`s visit to India in January 2024 a new agreement was signed which paved the way for joint patrol and surveillance of the Indian Ocean from Re-Union Islands. The United States already has Diego Garcia islands while India and US are defense partners. With such critical infrastructures present in the region India can form a network of infrastructure including the Agalega island, Reunion, Diego Garcia, and Seychelles to enhance the security architecture of the Indian Ocean and thereby ensure a rule-based order in the region. It will help combat both traditional security threats possessed by China as well as non-traditional issues of the Indian Ocean predominantly piracy and terrorism. These tiny islands have great potential to add strength to India`s national security infrastructures.

By utilizing these archipelagos sea power can be harnessed at its best to upgrade our national security facilities across the Ocean. Proper strategizing and multilateral partnerships are required in the maritime domain. No nation can unilaterally take steps when it comes to Ocean governance where as consensus-based negotiations should evolve which should be complimentary to national security too. In the Indian Ocean context, it is India`s responsibility to lead the rule-based free navigation narrative form effective partnerships with neighbours, and work on effective policies.

Conclusion:

Sea power is one of the most vitalizing elements not only in the National Security aspect for India but in all other means too. When the 7000 (approx.) kilometre vast coastline is used efficiently it would reward the Indian economy like never imagined before. When the given opportunity and value is high the threat and risk will also be high, especially in a current unstable broken world order. It is a tedious task to ensure ocean governance and keep the waters safe from foreign invasion.

In that case, the great Nicobar Project and the Agalega Island Project are potential game-changers in fortifying the Indian Ocean with critical infrastructure. The Great Nicobar project will uphold India`s economic and security interest in the Indian Ocean which be an assertive statement to the world that in the Indian Ocean, it will be India that dominates in all aspects. The project will open new ideas and narratives on how national security has shifted ocean-centric and by doing so what advantages India will get out of it. The Great Nicobar Project will not only reward traditional national security aspects like restricting foreign players' involvement it will be complimentary to the emerging narratives of national security like economic security, energy security, and food security. It will also be a testament to India`s leadership skills on how effectively India can ensure good governance in Oceans.

The Agalega Island project is a strong counter-strategic move to China`s increasing ambition in the Indian Ocean. It is proof that no matter what a foreign nation tries India`s superiority in the Indian Ocean cannot be challenged. It also shows the strategic choices and availability that India has regarding the Indian Ocean, and how diversified our strategies are. With the help of networking with like-minded partners in the Indian Ocean and taking joint actions, a strong network of security architecture can be built. But, this process should happen carefully so that smaller nations especially the island nations which are mostly dependent on bigger powers should not be exploited or feel insecure with the big power politics happening in their vicinity.

India for centuries has effectively used its sea power to expand its influence, trade, and culture, and sea power played an important role in keeping India`s civilizational character ahead of other civilizations. For centuries various kingdoms have also effectively protected these waters efficiently and won many naval wars. It is high time that lessons from history should taken seriously and National Security should be given more importance from an oceanic perspective which only then will ensure overall enhanced national security of the country for a Vikisit Bharath 2047.

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